

SECTION THREE

CULTURE, CUSTOMS & DAILY LIFE

Culture is the texture of your world. It's the unwritten rules everyone knows, the rituals that mark important moments, the things people do without thinking about them. How they greet each other, what they eat, what they believe about luck, how they raise their children, and what they do for fun. And in romantasy, culture is the invisible architecture that determines what your characters can and can't do, what it costs them to step out of line, and what hoops they have to jump through to be together.

The “Invisible Cage” Principle

Cultural boundaries create some of the most compelling constraints when they’re so much a part of your character’s world view that they are unseen by themselves. What we call love is what brings these into focus.

A character who has never questioned arranged marriage doesn’t experience it as oppression until they want to marry someone else. A character who assumes certain others are inferior to them does not recognise the limitations of their assumptions until they develop romantic feelings for one of those people. Those bars were always there. It’s when your character wants something on the other side of those bars that they begin to realise there are limits.

Feyre in *ACOTAR* is an excellent illustration of this. She never questions Tamlin’s protective nature or the rules of the Spring Court until she experiences Rhysand’s Night Court, where she’s given autonomy and actual choice. It was only through experiencing love from someone who treats her differently that Feyre realises the cage she has been living in. And the cage she had been living in was not due to Tamlin’s cruelty. It was Feyre genuinely believing that was what love looked like.

What does your character take for granted that love will make them realise?

- **Unquestioned norms:** “This is just how things are done.” Until doing things differently becomes the only way to be with the person they want.
- **Invisible hierarchies:** Differences in status that are normal to the character with the higher status but felt to be oppressive to the other character. The tension exists at the point when the privileged one finally sees it.
- **Internalised shame:** Characters that feel unworthy of love because their culture taught them they are less than others. Their partner will need to battle those feelings along with each external challenge.
- **Loyalty costs:** To choose love is to betray community, family, and tradition. The identity that the character held prior to love will no longer exist; the new identity will be one that their previous self would not recognise. That transformation *is* the story.

The invisible cage works because culture creates identity. Disobeying the law is an action. Defying your culture is an identity crisis. When your characters choose to follow their heart rather than their traditions, they are not merely breaking rules. They’re creating an entirely new identity for themselves, and that *is* the story.

The Key Question

What cultural assumption does your character accept without question at the start of the story? And what will loving this person force them to confront about their own world?

Map your character's invisible cage:

The invisible cage only becomes visible when your character wants something on the other side of the bars. This is the moment when culture stops being background and becomes the central obstacle of your romance.

	PROTAGONIST	LOVE INTEREST
What cultural rule do they accept without question at the start?		
What moment or person makes the cage visible?		
What do they lose by seeing it? (Certainty, community, identity?)		
What do they gain?		

How to Think About Culture in Romantasy

Culture in romantasy is a constraint system. It's the social rules that determine what your characters can and can't do, what it costs them to step out of line, and what hoops they have to jump through to be together.

The tighter the constraints, the higher the tension. A culture where unmarried people can't be alone together makes every stolen moment electric. Loose constraints work too, but then your tension needs to come from somewhere else.

Don't explain culture through exposition. Let readers discover the rules when characters follow them, break them, or face consequences for crossing them. A single scene of social awkwardness teaches more than a paragraph of worldbuilding ever could.

Culture as Obstacle

The rules your characters must navigate or break:

- Taboos against certain relationships (class, species, enemy nations)
- Required courtship progressions that can't be skipped
- Chaperoning requirements that prevent privacy
- Reputation systems where being seen together causes damage
- Family involvement that creates external opposition

Culture as Opportunity

The customs that create romantic moments:

- Festivals where normal rules relax
- Dances that allow sanctioned touch
- Gift-giving traditions that let characters express interest
- Ceremonies that force proximity
- Traditions that create meaningful gestures

Culture as Revelation

How characters interact with cultural expectations shows who they are:

- Do they follow rules out of belief or fear?
- Do they break rules impulsively or deliberately?
- Do they chafe against expectations or never question them?

Some of the most interesting romantic tension comes from pairing characters who relate to their culture differently. One who embodies its values, one who challenges them.

Common Patterns: Culture in Romantasy

PATTERN	HOW IT WORKS	WHAT IT CREATES
The forbidden touch	Culture restricts physical contact; every brush of hands becomes charged	Slow-burn tension; meaningful small gestures
The reputation gamble	Being seen together risks social ruin	Stakes for every private moment; secrets
The courtship ladder	Expected progression that can't be skipped	Frustration when feelings outpace propriety
The chaperoned dance	Must interact under watchful eyes	Stolen glances; coded communication
The festival exception	One night when rules relax	Pivotal scenes; masks and anonymity
The cultural mistranslation	Gesture means different things in different cultures	Misunderstanding; revelation when explained

Which cultural patterns does your world use?

Pick 2-3 patterns from the reference table above that fit your romance. For each, note how it shows up in your story.

PATTERN	HOW IT WORKS IN YOUR WORLD
<i>e.g., The forbidden touch — Fae cannot touch humans without burning them, so every accidental contact carries the weight of physical danger and forbidden desire</i>	

A Note Before You Begin

Not every question will apply to your story. Skip what doesn't fit.

If your world mirrors a real culture, focus on what's different. You don't need to invent every custom from scratch. Zero in on what deviates from what readers will assume, and on the elements that create friction for your romance.

Common Mistakes with Cultural Worldbuilding

Mistake #1: The Inconsistent Culture

Cultural rules apply when convenient and disappear when inconvenient. Characters are chaperoned in one scene and alone together the next with no explanation. Stakes that come and go feel fake. If readers can't trust that the rules are real, they won't feel tension about breaking them.

FIX

Establish your rules clearly and enforce them consistently. If characters break rules, show consequences. If rules relax in certain circumstances, establish that pattern early.

Mistake #2: The Paper-Thin Taboo

Something is supposedly forbidden, but no one seems to actually care. The "forbidden" lovers face disapproval but no real consequences. Forbidden love only matters if the forbidding is real. Stakes need teeth.

FIX

Make consequences concrete and serious. Show other characters who suffered these consequences so readers know the threat is genuine.

Mistake #3: The Monolithic Culture

Everyone in a society thinks the same way, follows the same rules. No internal variation, no rebels, no regional differences.

FIX

Show variation. Some people enforce rules strictly; others look the other way. Older and younger generations may differ. Your characters should be able to find allies and enemies within their own culture.

Cultural Worldbuilding Self-Check

Review the culture you've built so far. Check any that apply, then address the ones that need fixing.

MISTAKE	DOES THIS APPLY TO YOU?	WHAT TO FIX
Inconsistent Culture: Rules apply when convenient and disappear when inconvenient		
Paper-Thin Taboo: Something is supposedly forbidden, but no one seems to actually care and there are no real consequences		

MISTAKE	DOES THIS APPLY TO YOU?	WHAT TO FIX
Monolithic Culture: Everyone in the society thinks the same way with no internal variation, rebels, or regional differences		

Core Values & Worldview

Every single culture teaches its own set of fundamental beliefs: the virtues people learn in childhood, the attributes that make a person worthy of respect, the shortcomings that lead to shame. Your characters develop as a result of being shaped by those belief systems, even when they resist.

Because your characters are from different cultures, they have been raised on different values. So when their values collide (which will eventually happen), there is natural, authentic conflict. Allow your characters to grapple with fundamentally different views of life. The romance will grow stronger when they have to make genuine changes, not merely acceptance.

The Key Question

Which cultural values must your characters compromise or sacrifice to be together?

Reference: Cultural Values & Traits

Use this list when deciding what your culture values most. Pick 3-5 that define your world.

CATEGORY	POSSIBLE VALUES
Personal Virtues	Honour, loyalty, courage, humility, patience, wisdom, honesty, compassion, self-reliance, cunning

CATEGORY	POSSIBLE VALUES
Social Bonds	Family duty, clan loyalty, hospitality, community harmony, respect for elders, friendship, romantic love
Achievement	Ambition, excellence, competition, innovation, artistic mastery, scholarly pursuit, martial prowess
Spiritual	Piety, ritual observance, connection to ancestors, mystical insight, fate acceptance, divine service
Material	Wealth, status, land ownership, beautiful possessions, comfort, security, legacy
Freedom	Independence, personal choice, adventure, wanderlust, self-expression, breaking tradition
Order	Tradition, hierarchy, obedience, propriety, law, duty, sacrifice for the greater good
Power	Strength, dominance, conquest, political influence, magical ability, control, leadership

What does your culture value most highly?

List 3-5 core values in order of importance:

How do these values create tension for your characters?

Values create tension when two characters' cultures prize different things, or when the same culture's values conflict with what love demands. A culture that values duty above all makes choosing love feel like choosing selfishness.

YOUR ANSWER

What does your culture consider shameful or dishonorable?

The flip side of values — what brings disgrace:

YOUR ANSWER

How does one character embody the cultural ideal while the other challenges it?

CHARACTER	RELATIONSHIP TO CULTURAL VALUES
Protagonist	
Love Interest	

What cultural value must one or both characters sacrifice to be together?

What virtue do they have to abandon, or what shame must they accept?

YOUR ANSWER

Gender Roles & Expectations

Gender (or equivalent social categories in your world) shapes behaviour, opportunities, and relationship dynamics. In many cases, societal expectations regarding gender dictate who will pursue and who will be pursued, who has agency to act versus waiting to act. This is fundamental because it affects everything that follows: daily life, family, courtship, hierarchy, and what your characters are even allowed to want.

Showing constraint of gender through big dramatic confrontations doesn't necessarily convey well the ways in which gender constrains individuals. It's through many small, almost imperceptible friction points that you can best illustrate this. The dress she wears limits her range of motion. The conversation she is prevented from participating in. The assumption made by others regarding her desires without ever asking if those assumptions were correct. For example, a character who has issues with the constraints of gender may express rebellion through small acts: unbuttoned corsets, secret reading material, or stolen time for personal practice. Her actions and behaviours may also be altered depending upon who is observing her, or she may maintain an internal dialogue questioning the rules she publicly abides by.

Don't overlook the costs associated with conformity, either. There may be mental fatigue, emotional exhaustion due to self-censorship, and personal sorrow for choices not made. When two people that have been socially constructed in differing manners fall in love with one another, allow them to perceive one another differently than others do. The space between how society views them and how their lover views them is precisely where the romance is located.

What are the general expectations for different genders in your culture?

Focus on what affects your story:

ASPECT	EXPECTATIONS
Expected roles and behaviors	

ASPECT	EXPECTATIONS
Prohibited roles and behaviors	

How do these expectations affect your characters?

CHARACTER	HOW GENDER EXPECTATIONS AFFECT THEM
Protagonist	
Love Interest	

Does either character violate gender expectations?

How? What consequences do they face — social, legal, or personal?

YOUR ANSWER

How do gender expectations shape courtship?

Who pursues? Who waits? Who controls the pace?

YOUR ANSWER

What happens when the “wrong” person takes the lead in courtship?

When someone breaks the expected courtship dynamic — the woman proposing, the lower-status person initiating — the social reaction reveals how rigid or flexible your culture truly is, and how much your characters risk by defying expectations.

YOUR ANSWER

Daily Life & Routines

To understand how culture shapes romantic experiences, you have to begin with how people live their lives. Romance occurs in the context of daily routines. Examining the patterns of living reveals when a couple will encounter each other and what is considered “normal.”

The number of routines you choose to depict isn’t as important as establishing a baseline for readers’ perception of what is normal and how much of an impact a deviation from that norm has. A couple of lines about a character’s morning rituals (they always take their tea; they always say their prayers) illustrate what a distraction or change means. Routine is a good method for developing character as well: what does the character do first? When in a rush, what does the character skip? What is the small comfort the character would never give up no matter what?

As soon as romance enters into a character’s routine, the reader will be able to sense the difference due to the prior knowledge of what was considered “normal.” Their character begins to wake up thinking of someone. The regular walk back home has new feelings because there could be this person. These little changes resonate with the reader because the reader understands the context from before.

What’s the rhythm of a typical day?

TIME	WHAT HAPPENS
Morning (when do people wake? what happens first?)	
Midday (is there a rest period? a main meal?)	
Afternoon/Evening (when does work end? what follows?)	

TIME	WHAT HAPPENS
Night (when do people sleep? what's nightlife like?)	

How does this rhythm differ by class or profession?

HOW DOES THIS RHYTHM DIFFER BY CLASS OR PROFESSION?

What's the weekly or monthly rhythm?

Market days? Rest days? Religious observances? Regular social gatherings?

YOUR ANSWER

What do people do when they're not working?

Leisure, entertainment, socializing — what fills non-work hours?

YOUR ANSWER

How does the love interest disrupt your protagonist's routine?

Romance changes the texture of daily life. What shifts when your protagonist starts thinking about this person?

ROUTINE ELEMENT	BEFORE THE LOVE INTEREST	AFTER
<i>e.g., Morning tea ritual — Feyre used to eat alone at dawn, mechanically</i>	<i>Alone, silent, functional — tea was fuel, not comfort</i>	<i>She begins noticing whether Rhysand is already awake, listening for his movements, lingering over her cup</i>

Home & Household

Your home is the most intimate space in your world. It's the place where characters are most themselves. The way homes are constructed, how many people share them, and the amount of privacy they provide will determine when and where your characters can be vulnerable with each other. Homes shared with servants or other people create vastly different possibilities for romance than homes lived in alone.

How your point-of-view character reacts (or doesn't react) to what they see upon entering a home is an indicator of their past experience. A character raised in poverty will count every single thing of value; a character from wealth will likely never recognise anything about their surroundings as luxurious, but rather notice immediately if something feels wrong. Instead of saying "the home was rich" use specific objects like "silver candlesticks left casually on a side table, more books than she'd seen in her life, a fire burning in an empty room."

As your character first enters their love interest's home, take some time to allow them to understand who this person is based upon where they live. That is a type of intimacy in itself.

What does a typical home look like for different classes?

CLASS	HOME DESCRIPTION
Wealthy/noble	
Middle/merchant	
Common/poor	

Who lives together?

Nuclear families? Extended families? Multiple generations? Servants in the household? Unmarried adults with parents?

YOUR ANSWER

How much privacy exists within a home?

Private bedrooms? Shared sleeping spaces? Thin walls? Servants everywhere?

YOUR ANSWER

What makes a house a “home”?

What objects, rituals, or elements make a space feel like home in your culture?

YOUR ANSWER

What does your protagonist notice when they first enter the love interest's home?

A home reveals who someone truly is. What details catch your protagonist's eye — and what do those details tell them?

YOUR ANSWER

Family Structure & Relationships

Your characters' family is where their identity is formed prior to the story beginning; and also what they will be answering to once the story has begun. Expectations from their parents, siblings and other relatives will have commitments that conflict with those of romantic interests. In romantasy, family often acts as the first and most personal obstacle to finding true love.

A character caught between their feelings for another person and their obligation to their family is making a decision that your readers will relate to on a visceral level. You can show family dynamics through the little things: who speaks first at dinner, who always gives in to whom, whose opinion really matters even if there isn't an established order of authority. Approval from family members (and the lack of it) can speed up or kill a romance, and when a love interest gains the acceptance of a difficult parent, the reader also views this as a victory.

What's the typical family structure?

Who heads the household? How are decisions made? What's the hierarchy within a family?

YOUR ANSWER

What obligations exist between family members?

What do children owe parents? What do parents owe children? What about siblings, extended family?

YOUR ANSWER

How are children raised?

Who raises them (parents, extended family, nurses, community)? What are they taught? When do they start working or training?

YOUR ANSWER

What happens to orphans, unmarried adults, elderly without children?

How does the culture handle people outside the typical family structure?

YOUR ANSWER

How does family affect your characters' romance?

Family is often the first and most personal obstacle to love. Whose approval matters? Who will try to interfere? What power does a parent or elder hold over the match?

CHARACTER	FAMILY'S STANCE ON THE RELATIONSHIP	WHAT POWER THEY HAVE TO INTERFERE
Protagonist's family		
Love Interest's family		

Food & Meals

Food shows culture. The foods we eat, the ways we prepare them, and with whom we eat them can tell you a great deal about values, resources, and social bonds.

Don't have to invent a whole cuisine. Just focus on those aspects of food which will be relevant to your story: what would your characters share over a meal? What meal will they make for someone they love?

Eating together is one of the most simple ways to develop intimacy. When characters first begin to eat together, pay close attention to what they notice about each other's habits. Is she picking at her food? Is he eating as if he has no idea when his next meal will come? Cooking for someone is an act of caring. Use this in your writing. Refusing to eat with someone, or eating by yourself when you can be sharing a meal, also means something. To create a food scene that works well, you should slow down on the detail of the senses: the smell of the food, the warmth of a shared cup, the way a character tears apart their bread. Let the physical action of eating together do all the emotional work.

What's a typical meal like?

Meals are where your characters will share space, reveal habits, and build domestic intimacy. Knowing what people eat and how they eat it gives you the raw material for food scenes that do emotional heavy lifting.

MEAL	WHAT'S EATEN	HOW IT'S EATEN
Morning		
Midday		
Evening		

What's "special occasion" food vs. everyday food?

WHAT'S "SPECIAL OCCASION" FOOD VS. EVERYDAY FOOD?

What food rules or restrictions exist?

Religious restrictions? Class-based foods? Regional specialties? Seasonal availability?

YOUR ANSWER

What's the culture around drinking (alcohol or otherwise)?

When is drinking appropriate? What's drunk? What are drinking customs?

YOUR ANSWER

What are the rules around shared meals?

Who can eat together? Who eats first? Who serves? Are there forbidden combinations (class, gender, species)?

YOUR ANSWER

What does sharing a meal signify?

Friendship? Alliance? Courtship? Family acceptance? Sealing a deal?

YOUR ANSWER

What foods or drinks have romantic or special meaning?

Aphrodisiacs, festival foods, courting treats, magical foods:

YOUR ANSWER

Is there a meal where something important happens between your characters?

Food scenes do emotional heavy lifting — the shared cup, the meal cooked with care, the silence over a table. What's the setting? What's eaten? What happens?

YOUR ANSWER

Architecture & Building

The way that people construct buildings can tell us a lot about who they are. A desert palace won't look anything like a northern fortress. No degree in architecture is required to recognise this.

All you really need to do is think about what would make sense with regards to each environment. In hot climates it is essential to create shade and allow for airflow. In cold climates, it is necessary to create thick walls that can keep the cold out, as well as large fireplaces that provide warmth. These differences in climate will give your readers a sense of place when travelling from one region to another. (For more on how climate shapes building, see Section 1: Geography & Environment.)

The way you construct your scenes can also impact the development of those scenes in practical ways. Narrow corridors force characters to stand close together. Great halls allow for a wide separation of characters across large tables. And the person that knows where all of the hidden passages are has the upper hand over the person that does not. When you are thinking about romantic scenes, consider how the layout of the room impacts the distance between characters, the amount of privacy they have, and the power dynamic of the scene.

What architectural style dominates your main setting?

Research real-world architecture that inspires your world. Note distinctive elements like columns, arches, domes, and materials.

YOUR ANSWER

What do different types of buildings look like?

How can your protagonist tell a temple from a tavern at a glance?

BUILDING TYPE	DISTINCTIVE FEATURES
Palace/noble estate	
Temple/place of worship	
Merchant's home/shop	
Common dwelling	
Military/fortification	

How does a specific building's layout shape a romantic scene?

Narrow corridors force proximity. Great halls create distance. Hidden passages give one character power over another. Pick a key setting and map how its layout affects the dynamic between your characters.

SETTING	LAYOUT DETAIL	HOW IT AFFECTS THE ROMANTIC DYNAMIC
<i>e.g., Spring Court manor — long corridors with alcoves hidden behind tapestries</i>	<i>e.g., Characters can slip out of sight for a moment but footsteps echo, so they can always hear someone approaching</i>	

Religion & Spirituality in Daily Life

If religion has been a key aspect of your story, consider expanding upon it in Section 6: Religion, Myth & Prophecy. Focus on how religion is part of the everyday lives of your characters.

A person's religion in everyday life is based on habits, not theology. The small rituals people go through without thinking, the phrases that are spoken without thought, and the gestures that mark the different stages of each day. They provide for your world the "lived-in" quality, and help create a common (or conflicting) spiritual vocabulary among your characters.

Most religions are rooted in the small things: how someone prays before a meal, what someone says when receiving bad news, and a shrine that exists in almost every home. Inevitably, when two characters' religions clash, there will be conflict; and when two characters quietly pray together, there is intimacy. A character finding out that their love interest knows their prayer, or mouthing along with a blessing they don't believe in simply because they want to show respect, is an intimate gesture that provides significant romantic impact.

What role does religion/spirituality play in daily life?

These details will determine whether your characters share a spiritual vocabulary or must navigate different faiths — both of which shape the intimacy available to them.

Daily prayers or rituals? Religious dietary restrictions? Spiritual interpretations of everyday events?

YOUR ANSWER

What life events have religious significance?

Birth, coming of age, marriage, death — what rituals mark these transitions?

YOUR ANSWER

How do people interact with religious institutions or figures?

Priests, temples, shrines — how present are they in ordinary life?

YOUR ANSWER

What's considered sacred or profane?

What places, objects, words, or actions carry spiritual weight?

YOUR ANSWER

How does religion create tension or intimacy between your characters?

Do they pray to different gods? Does one character's faith demand something the other can't give? Is there a moment when one character quietly participates in the other's spiritual practice out of respect?

YOUR ANSWER

Superstitions & Folk Beliefs

Beyond formal religion, most cultures have their own folk beliefs. These are things everyone knows even though they can't tell you how they know. This little stuff makes a world that feels lived in.

These small superstitions will also show you how a person thinks by showing their character through what they do, not just by telling you. A hard-boiled soldier who still won't walk underneath a ladder tells you something that could never be told with words. Folk beliefs can generate small moments of connection or conflict for your characters too. Is one of your characters charmed by the other's superstition, or do they think they're foolish? If a superstition comes true, it could knock the ground right from underneath your characters' feet. And there's something sweet about a character that doesn't believe in good luck still carrying a charm because the person they love gave it to them.

Reference: Common Superstitions & Omens

Use this list for inspiration. Pick a few that fit your world's mood and culture.

CATEGORY	EXAMPLES
Lucky/Unlucky Numbers	Three for luck, seven for magic, thirteen cursed, odd numbers for the living, even for the dead
Animal Omens	Ravens mean death, white animals are blessed, black cats bring luck (or doom), owls warn of secrets
Weather Signs	Red sky warnings, thunder during weddings, rain on a journey's start, fog hiding spirits
Protective Actions	Iron wards off fae, salt purifies, crossing thresholds with right foot, spitting to avert evil eye
Bad Luck Triggers	Speaking a dead person's name, whistling at night, opening umbrellas indoors, breaking mirrors

CATEGORY	EXAMPLES
Good Luck Rituals	Knocking wood, throwing coins in water, carrying charms, first-footing at new year, bride's "something old"
Threshold Beliefs	Don't step on cracks, carry brides over doorways, leave offerings at crossroads, dawn/dusk are dangerous
Dreams & Visions	Dreams of water mean change, falling dreams warn of pride, dreaming of someone means they're thinking of you

What common superstitions exist?

Lucky/unlucky numbers, colors, animals? Actions that invite bad fortune? Protective gestures or phrases?

YOUR ANSWER

What everyday rituals do people perform without thinking?

Knocking on wood, crossing fingers, small offerings, phrases spoken at certain moments:

YOUR ANSWER

What do people believe about dreams, omens, or signs?

WHAT DO PEOPLE BELIEVE ABOUT DREAMS, OMENS, OR SIGNS?

What folk remedies or beliefs exist around health, love, or fortune?

WHAT FOLK REMEDIES OR BELIEFS EXIST AROUND HEALTH, LOVE, OR FORTUNE?

Does a superstition or folk belief play a role in your characters' relationship?

A charm given as a gift, a shared ritual that becomes "their thing," a superstition one character finds endearing in the other — small beliefs can create intimacy.

YOUR ANSWER

Manners, Etiquette & Everyday Politeness

Etiquette is an unwritten set of rules that we follow in our daily lives; which person says hello first, when does one stop speaking to allow another to go first. In romantasy, the “rules” of etiquette are a battleground for characters. Each time someone breaks some social rule you see something about where they come from, each deliberate violation is a statement of power and control, and the tension between what politeness requires and what desire demands drives countless charged scenes.

Do not tell your readers the rules of etiquette. Rather, show your readers the transgression and the subsequent reactions of those around them. Write down the immediate physiological response from others after the character makes a social faux pas: the gasp, the look shared among the people present, the pause in the conversation before the dialogue resumes. Allow your character to feel the wrongness of their actions before they have any idea why. And when depicting intentional violations of etiquette rules, show the internal calculation. Your character knows what they are risking and chooses to act anyway.

Etiquette becomes romantic tension as a result of one character watching another learn the “rules” of the world around them. The competence or ineptitude, the minute corrections that guide the newcomer, and the moment the outsider figures out the correct way to behave. A small social infraction is usually much more effective than a large offence: the cutting remark, the incorrect form of address, the turned shoulder.

How do people greet each other?

RELATIONSHIP	GREETING
Strangers	
Acquaintances	

RELATIONSHIP	GREETING
Friends	
Family	
Superior to inferior (class/age/rank)	
Inferior to superior	

What's considered rude in everyday interaction?

Behaviors that give offense, things that aren't done:

YOUR ANSWER

What's considered polite or hospitable?

Offering food/drink to guests? Specific gestures of respect? Customs around visiting someone's home?

YOUR ANSWER

How do people handle conflict or disagreement?

Direct confrontation? Indirect communication? Mediation through third parties?

YOUR ANSWER

What social mistake does one character make that the other notices?

Etiquette violations reveal where someone comes from and create charged moments between characters. What faux pas creates a scene between your protagonists?

THE MISTAKE	WHO MAKES IT	HOW THE OTHER REACTS

Hospitality & Guest Rights

While it may seem like hospitality would be a minor detail when building a world, in romantasy it can be one of the most dependable ways to generate romantic tension. Both of your characters are continually entering into each other's space, and the obligations that come from being a guest or a host establish a precarious, intimate dynamic that has a lot of opportunity.

Hospitality is ultimately a social contract. A host provides the guest with three things: safety, food and shelter, and passage from place to place. Guests have a few responsibilities: be polite, follow the host's house rules, and restrain their desires. Many fantasy worlds consider this contract sacred; a violation of it is more egregious than normal betrayal because it tears at the very fabric that holds together the community of strangers in hostile territory. In Fae-inspired settings, hospitality can literally become a binding contract. Each meal you eat, each gift you accept, and each word of gratitude you say can bind you to a host's obligation without even realising it.

One of the reasons that hospitality is such a great way to build tension between two people is the vulnerability that exists on both sides. As a guest, you're dependent on someone else's resources and therefore vulnerable and visible; there are rules you'll have to follow that you may not fully understand. The host is responsible for providing for another person, exposing themselves through their home and performing a version of themselves to an audience of one. By having your protagonist enter their love interest's home as a guest, the dynamic of vulnerability is already established by the time anyone starts speaking.

Hospitality in *A Court of Thorns and Roses* begins as a form of imprisonment for Feyre. She arrives at the Spring Court as a debtor, not a voluntary guest. Although Tamlin presents her stay as hospitality (fine clothes, beautiful rooms, all of her needs met), the true nature of her stay is as a captive. His hospitality becomes increasingly restrictive as time passes, culminating in him locking Feyre in the manor with an air shield for her "protection." While providing for her physical needs, Tamlin ignores her mental and emotional needs. After Feyre moves to the Night Court, Rhysand clearly states to her that she is his guest and not his prisoner. He reinforces this by teaching her how to defend herself, even within his own home. The two Courts were worlds apart: the difference between hospitality as a tool of control and hospitality as actual refuge.

Jude Duarte in *The Cruel Prince* is a perpetual guest living under conditions of precarious hospitality. After having been taken in by Madoc (a Fae General responsible for murdering her biological parents), she is educated and provided with the same luxuries as the Fae gentry, yet constantly reminded of her mortality and lower standing. Madoc provides for the children as a result of a sense of honour and obligation, as he views them as his wife's offspring. But this type of hospitality is both conditional and limiting. Perhaps the greatest betrayal of guest rights occurs when Valerian forces Jude to consume the Everapple, a fruit that renders people susceptible and compliant. This is a clear break in the trust

of the dining table, where feeding a guest is meant to be a sign of security. Jude's journey is largely

What does a guest owe their host?

Respect for house rules? Gifts? Restraint? What behaviour would violate guest rights? Are there things a guest must never do (ask certain questions, enter certain rooms, refuse offered food)?

YOUR ANSWER

What happens when hospitality is violated?

By either party. What are the consequences of betraying a guest or dishonouring a host? Is the penalty social, legal, magical, or divine?

YOUR ANSWER

How does your protagonist's guest status affect the romance?

Are they a willing guest, a reluctant one, or a prisoner in all but name? How does the power imbalance of guest and host shape the early dynamic between your characters?

YOUR ANSWER

Which hospitality pattern does your romance use?

These three patterns shape some of the most effective romantic dynamics in the genre. The gilded cage traps through luxury, the host's exposure creates accidental vulnerability, and the violation cuts deepest because it breaks a sacred trust.

PATTERN	DOES IT APPLY?	HOW IT SHOWS UP IN YOUR STORY
The gilded cage (luxury without autonomy)		
The host's exposure (home reveals truth)		
The violation (broken contract, deeper betrayal)		

What threshold rituals exist in your world?

The more elaborate the welcoming ritual, the greater the weight when it's violated. What must happen when a guest arrives — and what does it mean when someone skips a step?

YOUR ANSWER

Entertainment, Arts & Leisure

What your character does in their leisure time will show you what they value. The way characters interact with each other during leisure time also provides a natural setting for them to meet outside of their normal roles. The stories that are told, the games that are played, and the ways cultures express themselves through the arts all reveal deeper values about what really matters.

Leisure time is great for creating opportunities for your characters to spend time together while being outside of their normal relationship dynamic. A dance requires physical contact. A game shows how competitive someone is. A shared story creates inside jokes and common ground. In many cases, leisure activities provide a “cover” for characters to spend time together without acknowledging the real reason why they want to. And honestly, when a character continues to attend the same tavern game night over and over again, or has an unexplained sudden interest in an art form their love interest practises, it’s very obvious to everyone else. The transparent nature of this behaviour adds to its charm.

What entertainment is common?

Leisure activities give your characters excuses to spend time together outside their normal roles. A dance requires touch. A game reveals personality. A shared story creates inside jokes. What does your world offer?

Music, theater, games, sports, storytelling, gambling — what do people do for enjoyment?

YOUR ANSWER

What stories or legends does everyone know?

The cultural touchstones — tales children grow up hearing, references everyone understands:

YOUR ANSWER

What music exists? When is it played?

Instruments, styles, occasions for music:

YOUR ANSWER

What games or sports do people play?

WHAT GAMES OR SPORTS DO PEOPLE PLAY?

What art forms are valued?

Visual arts, crafts, performance, literature — what does this culture create and prize?

YOUR ANSWER

What leisure activity brings your characters together?

Dances require touch. Games reveal personality. Shared stories create inside jokes. What activity gives your characters an excuse to spend time together — and does everyone else see through the excuse?

ACTIVITY	WHAT IT ALLOWS (TOUCH, CONVERSATION, COMPETITION, PROXIMITY)	HOW OBVIOUS IS IT THAT THEY'RE THERE FOR EACH OTHER?
<i>e.g., Weekly tavern card game — Xaden starts showing up to a game he never attended before Violet joined</i>	<i>e.g., Seated across from each other, sustained eye contact, banter disguised as competitive trash-talk</i>	<i>e.g., Everyone at the table knows exactly why he's there except Violet</i>

Oaths, Promises & Honour

In many romantasy worlds, people's words carry value. Culturally, socially, and at times magically. Oaths of allegiance, sworn promises, and honour debts often create commitments which have the potential to create direct conflicts with the heart's desires. This theme of a person's word as a contract is especially prevalent in Fae-inspired settings; spoken words are literal contracts. When a bargain is made correctly, under the right circumstances, it creates a binding obligation, and the definition of "equal" repayment can lie completely with the other party.

The romantic tension in oath culture comes from collision. As soon as a character's sworn duty and their growing love are mutually exclusive, the tension begins. A character who swore to protect the realm now loves someone the realm considers a threat. A character who promised their dying parent they'd marry for alliance now wants to marry for love. A guard assigned to protect someone's purity finds himself dismantling the very rules he swore to uphold.

Oaths have an inherent value in romantic tension because they were normally given when the character had no idea what they would be losing. The oath seemed like no big deal at the time, since the oath did not conflict with anything the character wanted. It wasn't until the character develops romantic feelings for someone that the cost of the oath becomes apparent, and the commitment has already been made.

Oaths That Live in the Body

Romantasy worlds with the strongest oaths don't treat them as social norms; they give them physical consequences. What happens when you make a deal? It manifests as a tattoo that cannot be erased. When you break a promise, it causes you pain, sickness, or death. When your commitment lives in your body, ignoring it is impossible, and the tension between responsibility and passion becomes unendurable.

Romantasy oath culture has little resemblance to historical fiction. Where failure to honour your word can kill you, every single promise you make is a potential trap. Because the wording of the oath can be so important, characters in these worlds often treat every single word very carefully, not necessarily because they are clever, but because their life may depend on it. The distinction between "I will serve you" and "I will serve your interests" could be the difference between slavery and strategic alliance.

Rhysand and Feyre's bargain in *A Court of Thorns and Roses* is probably the most compelling use of oath-as-romantic-engine in the genre. Feyre bargained herself away to Rhysand for one week each month to stay alive while she was held captive Under the Mountain. This binding agreement is tattooed onto her body and remains even after she is transformed into a Fae, indicating that the promise is tied to the soul and not the body. When Feyre does not fulfil her part of the bargain for three months, she begins to experience the effects physically: nightmares, losing weight, becoming sick repeatedly. The rules and smart enough to work around them. Agency within constraint is the entire premise of romantasy, which disappear once she arrives at the Night Court. The bargain works like a somatic tether. She

What does breaking one's word cost in your culture?

Social disgrace? Exile? Loss of rank or magic? Physical pain? Somatic illness? Something worse?

YOUR ANSWER

Are oaths in your world purely cultural, or do they carry magical weight?

Can a bargain be literally binding? Does it manifest physically (a tattoo, a mark, a compulsion)? What happens if someone tries to break a magically enforced oath?

YOUR ANSWER

Does your world's oath system have loopholes?

Can precise wording be exploited? Is the letter or the spirit of the promise what matters? How might your characters use the system's rigidity to create space for personal choice?

YOUR ANSWER

What oath conflicts with your characters' romance?

Which promise must be broken, or creatively reinterpreted, for them to be together? Did the character know what they were giving up when they made the oath, or did love change the equation?

YOUR ANSWER

Write the oath.

If precise wording matters in your world, draft the actual words of the promise that binds your character. Then look for the loophole. What could those words mean that the speaker didn't intend?

	DETAILS
The exact words of the oath	

	DETAILS
Who it was sworn to	
What it was intended to mean	
What it could literally mean (the loophole)	
What it costs to break outright	

Taboos & Forbidden Things

The forbidden shows what the culture fears. In romantasy, taboos are the “forbidden love” stakes, and they will only be as effective as how well defined and important they are for each character involved. Forbidden love has its excitement in the risk involved. Ensure that your reader understands the consequences of breaking the taboo for each character before they do so. The first transgression must feel dangerous. Subsequent transgressions may increase the risk, or they may make the previously forbidden become acceptable. Both options can be used; however, having an idea of which you plan to use is helpful.

What actions, topics, or behaviors are taboo in your culture?

CATEGORY	TABOO BEHAVIORS
Physical (touch, proximity, eye contact, showing skin)	
Verbal (certain words, discussing feelings, speaking across gender/class)	
Social (cross-class interaction, public displays, being alone together)	
Magical (certain powers, displaying abilities, magical contact between people)	
Sexual (anything related to intimacy before or outside marriage)	

Which taboos directly affect your romance?

Pick 2-3 that create real obstacles:

TABOO	HOW IT AFFECTS THE ROMANCE

What happens when someone breaks a taboo?

Consequences should escalate with severity:

SEVERITY	CONSEQUENCE
Minor taboo broken	
Moderate taboo broken	
Major taboo broken	

What taboo do your characters break first?

This is often a pivotal early scene — the first boundary crossed:

YOUR ANSWER

What taboo must they break to be together fully?

This might be the climactic choice — the line they can't uncross:

YOUR ANSWER

Sexuality, Desire & Intimacy Norms

Every society has its own way of regulating desire. The question is: what counts as appropriate sexual behaviour, who can pursue whom sexually, and what happens to individuals (notably women) if they violate these norms? The answers to these questions reside at the centre of romantic conflict in the genre. In addition to external barriers such as war and geography, the expectations surrounding purity are internalised to the point that they become part of the character's inner dialogue, defining both what she does and what she believes she may or may not want.

So purity culture becomes such a potent tool in romantasy. As opposed to a character who is battling an external enemy, a character who is battling the voice within her own head that tells her *wanting this makes me ruined* is a very different type of struggle. The genre is particularly effective in conveying this type of conflict.

A very common structure in romantasy is what you might call the **architecture of restriction**: the culture creates elaborate rules regarding the protagonist's sexuality (veils, chaperones, ritualistic practices, physical isolation) and the romance develops as the rules are slowly dismantled. Each stolen glance, each forbidden touch, and each secret conversation carry the weight of the possible consequences of discovery. The restrictions themselves do half the heavy lifting of building up the slow burn for you.

In *From Blood and Ash*, the Maiden Rules demonstrate the architecture of restriction perfectly. Poppy is not simply expected to be a virgin; her entire existence is designed to reinforce that expectation. She is required to wear a veil, and to never be physically touched by anyone. She's forbidden from having direct eye contact with individuals, being spoken to informally, or having any physical contact with others. The rules create a double barrier; they restrict her ability to engage in sexual activity and her ability to develop a desire to begin with. So when Hawke arrives as her guard, one of the few people permitted to see her face, the simplest types of intimate contact (a glance, a casual conversation, a brush on the back) take on an enormous level of transgression. Poppy's rebellion begins not with a grand escape, but rather with a clandestine visit to a tavern where she wears a mask, thus trading one form of concealment for another, simply so that she may experience a kiss. The architecture of restriction makes even the smallest gestures of desire seem monumental.

But restrictions aren't sufficient alone. It is the **double standard** that allows these romance obstacles to operate; the difference between what is expected of women and what is allowed for men. In most romantasy worlds (and I am being truthful when I say it is the same way in many actual worlds) the male protagonist is expected to be a virgin, but his reputation and status will be unaffected if he is not. The female protagonist, on the other hand, is expected to be a virgin, and her reputation and status will be affected if she is not.

This double standard creates oppression in both directions. The female protagonist is expected to be a virgin, and her reputation and status will be affected if she is not. The male protagonist is expected to be a virgin, but his reputation and status will be unaffected if he is not. This double standard creates oppression in both directions. The female protagonist is expected to be a virgin, and her reputation and status will be affected if she is not. The male protagonist is expected to be a virgin, but his reputation and status will be unaffected if he is not.

How are these norms enforced?

Social shame? Physical punishment? Religious consequence? Loss of status or marriageability? Who does the enforcing: family, religious authorities, the community at large?

YOUR ANSWER

What happens to someone who violates these norms?

Particularly for women. What are the consequences of being perceived as sexually transgressive? Are they the same for men?

YOUR ANSWER

How does your protagonist's relationship with desire affect their romance?

Do they feel shame? Freedom? Confusion? Curiosity they've been taught to suppress? How does their love interest challenge or affirm their sense of self?

YOUR ANSWER

Where does the double standard live in your world?

What's permitted for one gender that would destroy the other? How does this asymmetry create tension between your characters?

BEHAVIOUR	CONSEQUENCE FOR THE PROTAGONIST	CONSEQUENCE FOR THE LOVE INTEREST
Being seen alone with someone		
Sexual experience/history		
Expressing desire openly		

Map the architecture of restriction — and the sequence of dismantling

If your protagonist lives under layers of rules designed to control their sexuality or intimacy, the romance develops as those layers are removed one by one. Map the restrictions from mildest to most extreme, then note which one falls first — and which one is the last to go.

LAYER OF RESTRICTION	WHAT RULE OR CUSTOM ENFORCES IT	WHEN DOES IT FALL IN THE STORY?
<i>The veil — Poppy cannot be seen by anyone outside the temple</i>	<i>Maiden Law, enforced by the priestesses and her guards</i>	<i>Falls first — Hawke sees her face when assigned as her guard</i>
<i>No informal speech — the Maiden cannot be addressed casually</i>	<i>Social custom, reinforced by everyone around her</i>	<i>Falls second — Hawke speaks to her like a person, not a title</i>
<i>No physical contact — she cannot be touched by anyone</i>	<i>Maiden Law, with physical separation enforced by her quarters and guards</i>	<i>Falls late — each touch escalates the stakes</i>

Reputation, Gossip & Public Opinion

In many cultures, how others perceive you can be just as important as your actions. Rumours spread quickly and reputation is often delicate. What once was, in some cases, could be irreversibly lost forever.

The way people react to your character when they enter a space can represent their feelings toward them. Does the room fall silent? Do people move closer or edge away? The quiet, unspoken comments your character cannot quite catch will heighten the reader's tension. Represent the pressure of the public's perception with the subtleties: the small, almost unnoticed slights, the intentional glances, and the closing of the door.

How does information travel in your society?

HOW DOES INFORMATION TRAVEL IN YOUR SOCIETY?

What destroys a reputation?

What's the kind of scandal that follows someone forever? Is it the same for all classes and genders?

POSITION	WHAT DESTROYS THEIR REPUTATION
Someone of the protagonist's position	

POSITION	WHAT DESTROYS THEIR REPUTATION
Someone of the love interest's position	

Can a ruined reputation be recovered? How?

Some cultures allow redemption; others don't. Is there a path back, or is ruin permanent?

YOUR ANSWER

Who are the gossips and rumormongers in your story?

Who spreads information — maliciously or carelessly? Who might your characters need to avoid, bribe, or silence?

YOUR ANSWER

What rumors might circulate about your characters' relationship?

Even if nothing has happened yet, what might people *say* is happening?

YOUR ANSWER

What’s the worst thing that could be said about either character?

The rumor that would destroy them — true or not:

CHARACTER	WORST POSSIBLE RUMOR
Protagonist	
Love Interest	

How do your characters protect their reputations while pursuing each other?

What precautions do they take? What lies do they tell? What image do they maintain?

YOUR ANSWER

Privacy, Surveillance & Being Watched

It is when we are denied our private moments that we begin to value them. But private moments are hard to come by; it is this lack of privacy that creates the feeling of earning intimacy.

Private time can vary dramatically from one culture to another. For some people, being alone in a room together is scandalous, while a busy marketplace provides far more anonymity than an empty hallway where servants have eyes and ears everywhere. It is because privacy is so rare that every stolen moment means something. A near-discovery builds beautiful tension: the footsteps in the hallway, the knock on the door, the voice in the next room. The fact that you are always aware that you could be discovered at any time makes every private glance dangerous.

The process of creating their own privacy together is itself a type of intimacy. They discover a secluded place. They fabricate reasons for being alone. They get to know each other's schedules. Together, they create a private world that only they share.

How much privacy exists in your world?

Consider: Do servants see everything? Do nobles have private chambers? Do commoners share living spaces? Is magical surveillance possible?

YOUR ANSWER

Where can your characters be alone together?

List the spaces where privacy is possible — and what risks each location carries:

LOCATION	RISK OF DISCOVERY

Where are they always watched?

Courts, public spaces, family homes, workplaces — where is privacy impossible?

YOUR ANSWER

Who might be watching or listening?

Servants, guards, family members, rivals, magical surveillance, spies:

YOUR ANSWER

What would happen if they were seen together?

CONTEXT	CONSEQUENCE
Seen talking privately	

CONTEXT	CONSEQUENCE
Seen alone together	
Seen in physical contact	

What excuse or cover story do they use when almost caught?

WHAT EXCUSE OR COVER STORY DO THEY USE WHEN ALMOST CAUGHT?

Is there a moment in your story when they ARE seen?

Who sees them? What happens next?

YOUR ANSWER

Touch, Proximity & Physical Boundaries

In many societies, there are rules about who may physically touch whom, and to what extent. Touch restrictions have the power to create a slow burn feeling in romance. When a simple brush of the fingers with another person is seen as taboo, it carries a charge that explicit contact in a more permissive culture simply can't match.

Accidental touches are electrified in these societies. Write the moment your main character's hand brushes against another person's, and they both stop dead in their tracks. The warmth of being too close to each other in a crowded room. The more forbidden touch is, the more weight a single point of contact carries.

Bridgerton is a perfect example of this. In a Regency setting where unmarried people can barely be alone together, every gloved hand on an arm carries weight. When Anthony removes Kate's bee sting in The Viscount Who Loved Me, although it was strictly a medical procedure, the transgression of touching bare skin in that world made it one of the most charged scenes in the book. You do not have to include any form of explicit content, as placing a hand on a bare shoulder in some societies would be scandalous enough.

What touch is considered appropriate between unmarried people?

Map the boundaries:

CATEGORY	WHAT'S INCLUDED
Always acceptable	
Acceptable in certain contexts (chaperoned, public, formal)	

CATEGORY	WHAT'S INCLUDED
Borderline or scandalous	
Absolutely forbidden	

What physical distance is expected between unmarried people?

WHAT PHYSICAL DISTANCE IS EXPECTED BETWEEN UNMARRIED PEOPLE?

What touch is considered particularly intimate — perhaps more so than a kiss?

What's YOUR culture's unexpected intimacy?

YOUR ANSWER

When do your characters first break the touch barrier?

Describe the scene — what boundary do they cross? Was it intentional or accidental? How do they react?

YOUR ANSWER

What touch do they share in private that they couldn't share in public?

The contrast between public restraint and private contact creates tension:

YOUR ANSWER



Are unmarried people allowed to be alone together?

If no — who must be present? Under what circumstances can they be unchaperoned?

YOUR ANSWER

Who acts as chaperone for your characters?

Is this person sympathetic, oblivious, or hostile to the romance?

YOUR ANSWER

How do they evade supervision?

What excuses, distractions, or locations allow them to be alone?

YOUR ANSWER

If they ARE alone together, what does that imply?

Does it automatically suggest impropriety? Is their reputation ruined? Are they now obligated to marry?

YOUR ANSWER

Dress, Appearance & Adornment

Dressing tells us who we are: our social standing, how available we are, our values and beliefs. In addition, clothing creates its own romantic tension. The veil that cannot be removed, the colour that says “do not speak to me,” the hair that only your spouse can see unbound.

Dress in detail and observe what your characters pay attention to when it comes to each other’s clothes. What your protagonist focuses on with regards to another character’s appearance will give your readers an idea of where their eyes keep going back to: how fabric falls, a scar that is hidden under the edge of a collar, a ring that is or isn’t being worn.

Transitions in wardrobe also serve well as indicators of how intimate the relationship has become. Armour removed, hair unbound, formal wear discarded. Each layer of clothing that is removed is a layer of distance that has been removed.

What Clothing Signals

What does clothing communicate in your culture?

MARKER TYPE	WHAT CLOTHING COMMUNICATES
Class markers	
Profession markers	
Marital/availability markers	

MARKER TYPE	WHAT CLOTHING COMMUNICATES
Religious markers	

Are there sumptuary laws — rules about who can wear what?

Certain fabrics, colors, or styles restricted to certain classes? Penalties for dressing “above your station”?

YOUR ANSWER

What would it mean for your character to dress outside their station?

Disguise? Scandal? Crime? Social death?

YOUR ANSWER

Fashion by Class & Context

What do people actually wear? You don't need to describe every stitch, just know enough to make your descriptions feel true when they matter to the scene.

CONTEXT	WEALTHY/NOBLE	COMMON/WORKING
Daily wear		
Formal events		
Work/labour		
Religious occasions		
Mourning		
Wedding/celebration		

For historical fashion terminology (chemise, doublet, kirtle, stays, etc.), see Section 20: Quick Reference Sheets.

What are your world's distinctive garments?

What clothing exists in your world that doesn't exist in ours? Magical garments? Cultural specifics?

YOUR ANSWER

Covered & Revealed

What parts of the body are typically covered?

What's modest dress in your culture? Does it differ by gender, class, or context?

YOUR ANSWER

What's considered scandalous or provocative to reveal?

WHAT'S CONSIDERED SCANDALOUS OR PROVOCATIVE TO REVEAL?

What does revealing something usually hidden mean?

If someone shows skin they normally cover, what does that signal? Trust? Intimacy? Invitation? Shame?

YOUR ANSWER

Is there something one character shows the other that they don't show anyone else?

A physical vulnerability? A hidden mark? Simply their unguarded appearance?

YOUR ANSWER

Hair & Its Meanings

What do hairstyles signify in your culture?

Bound vs. loose? Cut vs. uncut? Covered vs. uncovered? Specific styles for specific statuses?

YOUR ANSWER

Is there significance to who can touch someone's hair?

Is it intimate? Forbidden? Reserved for family or spouse?

YOUR ANSWER

Is there a moment when one character sees the other's hair differently than usual?

Unbound, wet, disheveled, cut — and what does it mean?

YOUR ANSWER

Tokens of Dress

Are there clothing items exchanged in courtship or marriage?

Rings, pins, sashes, cloaks, veils — items that mark someone as courting or claimed?

YOUR ANSWER

What does it mean to give or receive such an item?

Interest? Betrothal? Binding commitment?

YOUR ANSWER

What does it mean to remove or reject such an item?

WHAT DOES IT MEAN TO REMOVE OR REJECT SUCH AN ITEM?

Is there a garment or accessory that becomes significant between your characters?

Something given, borrowed, kept, or returned:

YOUR ANSWER

Undressing as Intimacy

What does it mean to see someone in states of undress?

WHAT DOES IT MEAN TO SEE SOMEONE IN STATES OF UNDRESS?

When do your characters first see each other less than fully dressed?

What are the circumstances? What does each see?

YOUR ANSWER

What layers come off over the course of the relationship?

Each layer removed is a layer of distance dissolved. Map the progression — from the first small reveal to the moment when they're fully unguarded around each other.

STAGE OF RELATIONSHIP	WHAT'S REMOVED OR REVEALED	WHAT IT SIGNIFIES
<i>Early (formal, guarded)</i>	<i>She removes her gloves in his presence — the first time she's shown bare hands</i>	<i>A crack in the armour; she's stopped performing</i>

Is there a garment that represents armor or protection that one character removes around the other?

Literal armor? A mask? Formal court dress? Religious garments? What does removing it signify?

YOUR ANSWER

Courtship Customs & Romantic Expectations

All cultures have a romantic script: the expected ways to indicate interest, as well as the approved sequence of events from stranger to spouse. If we don't understand what the normal expectations of these scripts are, then the deviations may be difficult to identify.

The romantic tension in courtship customs comes from the gap between what's expected and what's felt. There is a character performing the required actions but burning beneath the surface. A character who has no idea where they are in the process, and must be guided by the person they're interested in. And then there is the intimacy of learning how to perform the scripted actions. You want to portray characters who are acutely aware of which step in the process they are currently engaged in, constantly trying to determine if they can skip over the next step, frustrated with the rigid pacing that doesn't match their feelings. Once a couple deviates from the script, it should be apparent that both parties involved are conscious of what they are doing. "This is not the way things are typically done," one party may express, and the other responds, "I am aware." The script becomes most important once the couple deviates from it.

In *From Blood and Ash*, Poppy has lived her entire life adhering to the rules of the Maiden. She is never allowed to be touched, seen, or spoken to informally. So every time Poppy and Hawke interact and break one of these rules, there is a sense of tension present precisely because both are aware of what the rules are, and are purposefully ignoring them. The courtship is not characterised by romantic gestures such as flowers or formally introducing themselves. Rather, it's comprised of secretly conversing with one another, forbidden touch, and slowly breaking down every rule that Poppy has been taught since birth. With each step they skip, there is a sense of danger present because the consequences are real.

How do people show romantic interest?

What's the cultural script for "I'm interested in you"?

YOUR ANSWER

What's the expected progression of a relationship?

Map the steps from “strangers” to “married”:

Who initiates courtship?

One gender? Either? Families? Does it vary by class?

YOUR ANSWER

What's the role of family in courtship?

Must families approve? Arrange meetings? Give formal consent? Or do individuals choose freely?

YOUR ANSWER

How long is a typical courtship?

Weeks? Months? Years? Is a long courtship expected, or can people marry quickly?

YOUR ANSWER

How do your characters violate courtship expectations?

Do they skip steps? Move too fast? Pursue when they shouldn't? Ignore family involvement?

YOUR ANSWER

What does it mean if someone violates the expected progression?

VIOLATION	WHAT IT SIGNALS
Moving too fast	
Skipping family involvement	
Pursuing someone “above” them	

What gestures are considered romantic in your culture?

Describe 3 gestures that signal love or interest:

What gestures would be considered too forward or inappropriate?

What romantic gesture does one character make that surprises the other?

Something that reveals more than they intended, or that the other didn't expect:

YOUR ANSWER

Tokens, Gifts & Symbols

Gifts in the context of courtship can be thought of as their own unique form of communication. The right gift at the right time signals interest; too much interest, however, can communicate presumptuousness or even ignorance of the recipient.

Each gift scene has three components: the act of giving, the act of receiving, and the after-effects. To maximise the impact of each of these elements, slow down through all three. The giver: what did they give? Why did they choose this gift? How nervous or confident were they when presenting? Did they offer explanation or allow the gift to stand for itself? The receiver: the moment of recognition (or confusion), physical contact with the gift, the decision on how to respond. The aftermath: where does the gift go? How many times is the gift physically touched or looked at? Is the gift put away, or placed out for view? While the actual gift itself is important, the emotional weight the giver places upon it carries much greater significance. But specific gifts chosen based on some preference or observation carry much greater weight than generic “beautiful jewellery.” A gift that reflects the giver’s awareness of the receiver (remembered a preference, noticed a need) will always land harder than an expensive gift that merely demonstrates wealth.

Are there traditional courtship gifts or tokens?

What objects carry romantic meaning? (Flowers, jewelry, handkerchiefs, enchanted items, etc.)

YOUR ANSWER

What does giving or accepting such a token signify?

Interest? Serious intent? Engagement? Binding commitment?

YOUR ANSWER

Does either of your characters give such a token — or refuse one?

What happens and what does it mean?

YOUR ANSWER

Is there an object that becomes meaningful to your couple specifically?

Not a traditional token, but something that gains significance between them:

YOUR ANSWER

Plan a gift scene using the three components.

The most powerful gift scenes slow down through all three stages: giving, receiving, and aftermath. A gift that shows the giver noticed something specific about the receiver always lands harder than one that merely demonstrates wealth.

COMPONENT	DETAILS
The gift (what is it? why this gift specifically?)	
The giving (how nervous/confident? explanation or silence?)	
The receiving (recognition, confusion, physical contact with the gift)	

COMPONENT	DETAILS
The aftermath (where does the gift go? how often is it touched or looked at?)	

Marriage Customs & Ceremonies

Marriage is where individualised love becomes a public rite of passage. Who can marry whom? What rituals must be performed? What makes a union legitimate? These customs define the endgame of your romance and the obstacles standing in its way.

These customs will determine whether your characters are rushing towards marriage or trying to escape it. Weddings create great set-piece moments. Since they are public, the ceremony can increase tension: the vows have to be said out loud, the witnesses can watch for hesitation, the moment when an objection can be raised. No matter whether the couple is getting married with open arms or against their will, the ceremony should have a sense of finality. Take your time to describe what your character sees, hears, and feels during the ceremony, and let the ritual carry the emotional weight.

What makes a marriage “real” in cultural terms — beyond legal requirements?

Religious ceremony? Community witness? Consummation? Exchange of vows? Magical binding? Family blessing?

YOUR ANSWER

Describe a traditional wedding ceremony in your world:

ELEMENT	DESCRIPTION
Setting	
Who performs it	
Key rituals or moments	
Words or vows spoken	
Objects or symbols used	

What happens after the ceremony?

Reception? Consummation rituals? Wedding night traditions? Period of seclusion?

YOUR ANSWER

Are there different marriage customs for different classes, species, or magical groups?

If so, what are the key differences?

YOUR ANSWER

If your characters marry, how does their ceremony differ from tradition?

Do they follow all customs, some, or none? What does this choice reveal?

YOUR ANSWER



Can people marry secretly or elope?

Is this culturally acceptable, scandalous, or meaningless without public recognition?

YOUR ANSWER

What makes a secret marriage feel “real” to the people in it?

Even without official ceremony, what ritual or words would make it meaningful?

YOUR ANSWER

If your characters had a secret ceremony, what would it look like?

Where would it happen? What would they say or do? Who (if anyone) would witness?

YOUR ANSWER

Death, Grief & Mourning

Death customs help shape the way a culture approaches romance and many of its most emotional moments. Rituals surrounding the dead, what is owed to the deceased, whether grief is performed publicly or hidden away, and whether remarriage is permitted or shameful. All of these factors will influence the plot of your romance. What your characters believe about the end of life will colour how they view love and ultimately how they approach it.

Death customs can provide the most obvious romantic obstacle in the form of a **mourning period**: a socially or magically enforced period of time where the bereaved are separated from the world of the living, and therefore from the world of romance. Historically, Victorian widows were expected to wear black for over two years, progressing through stages of “deep mourning” to “half mourning” in specific increments. In romantasy, mourning customs can be even more restrictive, including restrictions against dancing, socialising, wearing colours, and being visible in public. The mourning period serves to enforce a waiting period in the characters’ lives; developing romantic feelings towards another person during this time carries an added layer of guilt because wanting someone while you are supposed to be grieving the loss of someone is seen as a betrayal of the deceased.

But death customs do more than just create a waiting period; they also serve to define the characters. Are your characters careful with the dead? Do they mourn with others? Are they open with their grief, or do they keep it inside? Do your characters follow customs they don’t believe in out of a deep respect? These answers will give the reader insight into who they are at their deepest level. If a character is willing to risk their safety to retrieve a body for proper burial, this shows that they have the capacity for selfless acts of caring, and therefore they are emotionally mature. And if a character refuses to take part in the outward signs of mourning, but displays deep, genuine grief in private, this reads as more emotionally honest and complex.

Grief is the unseen force driving both central relationships in *A Court of Thorns and Roses*. Rhysand has built a whole identity on unaddressed grief for the murders of his mother and sister by Tamlin’s father and brothers. As such, he believes that anything he loves will eventually be taken away from him and keeps his true feelings and mating bond with Feyre hidden to protect himself. At the same time, Feyre is grieving the loss of her humanity, as she died and was resurrected as High Fae. The symptoms she displays (nightmares, dissociation, physical illness) are classic trauma responses, yet in the Spring Court, these are dismissed. The romantic obstacle isn’t just that Tamlin is controlling; it’s that he is unable to deal with his own grief, so he can’t hold space for hers. Because Rhysand acknowledges

her pain and provides Feyre with the room to feel it, he offers something Tamlin structurally cannot. Because of this fundamental difference in how each of them experiences and processes grief, one relationship is broken, and a new one can emerge.

Death is far from abstract in *The Cruel Prince*. When Jude was only seven years old, she witnessed her parents' murder at the hands of Madoc. The Fae around her have become detached and nonchalant about death; during a royal coronation where the entire royal family is slaughtered, the celebration continues without a care. This cultural indifference to mortality is itself a source of conflict. Jude is aware that because she is mortal and the Fae are immortal, she is fragile and ephemeral, and that perception affects all of her interactions with Cardan. It is her knowledge that death is final that makes her ruthless, and it gives her an advantage over the immortals surrounding her.

In *Fourth Wing*, the dragon bond causes a series of events to occur once one partner dies: the bonded dragon dies, which kills the other bonded rider. Because there is an irrefutable mathematical certainty of shared mortality, Violet and Xaden are invested in each other's survival prior to developing an emotional connection. When Liam, Xaden's friend and Violet's protector, is killed, this is the moment that finally allows Violet to break down her defences and accept that death is not some distant concept in their world. It is this shared mourning for Liam that begins to unite them to a greater extent than before, developing a shared purpose that deepens into something more personal.

When developing mourning traditions for your world, there are several dynamics worth thinking about:

Grief as a psychological barrier. A character that has lost someone they loved will likely believe that when they lost that person, they also lost their ability to love. Therefore, a new love interest must find a way to help the character overcome the idea that loving again is a betrayal, by dismantling the character's internal beliefs that prevent them from feeling. This is a primary driver of the slow burn: the pining isn't just about external separation but about a character who won't allow themselves to feel.

Mourning as public performance. In some cultures, grief must be visible: specific clothing, wailing rituals, professional mourners, public vigils. In others, grief must be hidden; stoicism is valued, and those who visibly show their grief are viewed as weak. Both create romantic tension, but in different ways. Public mourning makes the bereaved conspicuous and untouchable. Private mourning creates a secret emotional world that only someone very close would be allowed to witness.

The taboo of loving again. In worlds with soul bonds or fated mates, the tie is frequently described as a tie that transcends death and even reincarnation. If your culture views the bond as eternal, then loving someone new isn't just moving on. It would represent a metaphysical betrayal. The "widow's

veil” (literal or metaphorical) becomes an obstacle to intimacy that could not be overcome through conversation alone.

Shared mourning as a bond. When two characters grieve together, following rituals, sitting vigil, performing rites for someone they both loved, the experience creates a connection that is qualitatively different from anything else in the story. They have witnessed each other in a completely raw state, with no pretences or social masks to hide behind. Like shared danger, shared grief can rapidly advance a relationship, because it forces individuals to present their true selves emotionally.

What are the mourning customs in your culture?

ASPECT	CUSTOM
Mourning period (how long, what’s expected)	
Mourning dress or symbols	
Restrictions during mourning (social, romantic, business)	

How does your culture treat the dead?

Burial, cremation, sky burial, magical dissolution? Is there a ritual that must be performed? What happens if the rites aren’t completed — does it affect the dead, the living, or both?

YOUR ANSWER

What are the rules around loving again after loss?

Is remarriage permitted? Expected? Shameful? Does it depend on how long they wait, who died, or how they died?

YOUR ANSWER

Can someone in mourning pursue romance?

Is courtship forbidden during mourning? For how long? What happens if they violate this?

YOUR ANSWER

How does grief affect your characters or their relationship?

If one character is mourning, how does this impact what's possible between them? Does shared grief bring them together?

YOUR ANSWER

How do your characters treat the dead they encounter?

A character who pauses to close a stranger's eyes or say a prayer reveals something about their capacity for tenderness. A character who walks past without looking reveals something too.

YOUR ANSWER

Life Stages & Coming of Age

Each culture establishes a point at which an individual is no longer a child, and that threshold indicates when they become eligible for romance, responsibility, and independent choice. The traditions surrounding this transition are crucial to understanding your character's past and can provide a pivotal moment within your story.

These transitions also establish natural turning points. A character who was not allowed to marry yesterday may have no problem getting married today, and that creates decisions they weren't prepared to face. The transition from childhood to adulthood could occur over a single night. In romantasy, the coming-of-age moment often coincides with the beginning of the romantic plot: the character becomes eligible, visible, or available in a way they weren't before.

What marks the transition to adulthood?

Age? Ceremony? Achievement? Magical awakening? Physical maturity?

YOUR ANSWER

What can people do as adults that they couldn't do as children?

Marry without consent? Own property? Make contracts? Use certain magic? Live independently?

YOUR ANSWER

Are your characters considered adults?

If not — how does this create obstacles? Are they defying expectations by acting before they're "ready"?

YOUR ANSWER

Are there other significant life transitions that affect your story?

Coming-of-age ceremonies, magical awakenings, trials, presentations at court, etc.?

YOUR ANSWER

Does a coming-of-age transition trigger the romantic plot?

Does your character become eligible for courtship, gain new powers, or enter a new social context because of a life transition? How does this change what's possible between them and the love interest?

YOUR ANSWER

Children & Education

A culture's beliefs are shown through how it brings up its youth. There are cultures that focus on discipline, there are cultures that focus on creativity. Some educate everyone equally; others reserve knowledge for the elite.

Think about what a childhood would be in your world. The way your characters were brought up shaped them into adults, and as adults with children or children-to-be, your answers to these questions can be very personal. Childhood backstory is one of the best methods to describe a grown person's behaviour. A child raised to fight shows affection differently than one raised to charm. Memories of upbringing deepen characterisation: what lessons stuck, what they rejected, what they wish they'd learned. And when characters discuss how they'd raise children together, they're revealing their deepest values.

How are children educated?

CLASS/GROUP	HOW THEY'RE EDUCATED
Noble/wealthy	<i>e.g., Private tutors in languages, history, etiquette; boys learn combat and governance; girls learn household management and diplomacy</i>
Middle/merchant	
Common/poor	<i>e.g., Learn their parents' trade by working alongside them; basic numeracy from market haggling; most cannot read</i>

CLASS/GROUP	HOW THEY'RE EDUCATED
Magical children	

How do most people learn skills and knowledge?

Apprenticeship? Formal schools? Family teaching? Religious institutions?

YOUR ANSWER

Who has access to education?

Is literacy common? Are schools available to all classes? Gender differences in education?

YOUR ANSWER

What knowledge is valued vs. dismissed?

Book learning vs. practical skills? Magical knowledge vs. mundane? Traditional knowledge vs. innovation?

YOUR ANSWER

Are there institutions that take children from their families?

Temples, military academies, magical schools, noble fostering arrangements? What does separation mean?

YOUR ANSWER

How were your main characters raised?

Their upbringing shaped who they are. What was childhood like for them?

CHARACTER	HOW THEY WERE RAISED
Protagonist	

CHARACTER	HOW THEY WERE RAISED
Love Interest	

Work & Professions

How does culture view work?

Is labor dignified or demeaning? Is idleness virtuous (noble leisure) or sinful? Do people identify strongly with their professions?

YOUR ANSWER

What professions are respected? Looked down upon?

STATUS	PROFESSIONS
Highly respected	

STATUS	PROFESSIONS
Respectable	
Necessary but low- status	
Disreputable or shameful	

How do people typically end up in their professions?

Family tradition? Personal choice? Assignment? Class restrictions?

YOUR ANSWER

PART TWO: CULTURE & ROMANCE

Festivals, Holidays & Celebrations

Special occasions have a way of shrinking time, bringing people close to one another, and heightening emotions. They're classic romance settings because the energy is different, rules may relax, and everyone is gathered in the same place.

The environment created by festivals gives characters an excuse to be different than they normally would. A character's face hidden behind a mask, the need to touch while dancing, the tradition that pairs strangers together. You can use these as excuses for intimacy your characters couldn't otherwise justify. And at the end of the festival, the urgency kicks in too. This chance won't come again.

What major festivals or celebrations exist in your world?

Describe 2-3 that matter for your story:

FESTIVAL	WHEN & WHAT IT CELEBRATES	KEY TRADITIONS

Which festival provides a romantic opportunity for your characters, and why?

WHICH FESTIVAL PROVIDES A ROMANTIC OPPORTUNITY FOR YOUR CHARACTERS,
AND WHY?

What festival tradition do your characters participate in together?

Describe the scene:

YOUR ANSWER

Do festivals allow any relaxation of normal rules?

Masquerades where identity is hidden? Festivals where class mingles? Nights when normal rules are suspended?

YOUR ANSWER

Exile, Banishment & Social Death

Every society uses a most extreme form of punishment to dissuade individuals from violating the norms: total removal from society. Exile, banishment, and social death represent the ultimate consequence of choosing love over community, and the fear of being exiled provides actual weight to each transgression. This is the nuclear option. Every time your characters violate a societal norm, the possibility of exile is what makes even the smallest violations feel dangerous.

Exile in romantasy takes several forms, and the form matters for your romance:

- **Political banishment:** The state exerts its power by physically removing the character from the territory through decree, forcing them to survive in an unfamiliar or hostile environment.
- **Self-imposed exile:** A character who voluntarily becomes a pariah to protect others, hiding behind a villain's mask, leaving home to keep a secret safe. The cost is reputation and identity, and the romantic obstacle is that the love interest must see past the performance to the real person underneath.
- **Social ostracism:** The character remains physically present but is treated as invisible, contaminated, or dead. Generational guilt, racial branding, or species-based prejudice mark them as permanent outsiders within their own community.
- **Cultural divorce:** The character rejects the beliefs, religion, or traditions of their people. They're not cast out by others; they walk away. But the safety net vanishes, and the romantic relationship must replace the entire support structure they've abandoned.

What makes exile such a potent romantic stake is the fact that it forces a character to redefine who they are. A character that has been stripped of their community, their title, and their position within the social hierarchy must discover who they are without those markers. That is frightening. But it is also the prerequisite for the kind of raw vulnerability that the strongest romances require.

Jude's exile at the end of *The Wicked King* is a brilliant example of exile as romantic catalyst. After being sent back to the mortal world, the place she tried to leave her whole life, Jude is deprived of everything she had worked toward: her status, her authority, her sense of purpose. The loss of her position causes a great deal of psychological damage. She experiences nightmares where Cardan tells her she is nothing. Her post-exile reality is characterized by working menial jobs and planning her revenge from a position of complete powerlessness. What makes Jude's exile so effective as a romantic moment is that it comes directly from the love interest himself, creating a wound that is both deeply personal and entirely politically motivated. Although it is later revealed that the exile was simply a

loophole (specifically worded to protect her from assassins of the court), the emotional devastation remains intact. When Jude returns, she does so not as a suppliant but as someone who has emerged from the void. The exile served as a narrative winnowing that demonstrated she is more than her title, and therefore her restoration as High Queen carries even greater weight because she earned it back from nothing.

Social ostracism takes a physical form in *Fourth Wing*. The “marked ones,” 107 children of the Tyrrish Rebellion, bear magic tattoos that identify them as the offspring of rebels. Xaden Riorson, their leader, has 107 additional scars etched across his back, one for each child whose life he bartered his own body to save. As a result of this inherited exile, the marked ones are both condemned and distrusted by the very institution they are compelled to serve. Xaden’s romance with Violet, the daughter of the general who ordered his father’s execution, is rooted in the tension between his deep-seated distrust of the establishment and his increasing need for the woman who represents it. For Violet, choosing Xaden means sacrificing every single thing she has ever believed about her nation. They resolve this by creating something entirely new: the city of Aretia, where the marked ones will no longer bear the branding of Navarre. Xaden’s exile does not end with reintegration into the old system. It ends with the creation of a new one.

Rhysand in *ACOTAR* represents a different type of exile: the self-imposed outcast. To protect Velaris and its people, he allows the entire world to believe he is a monster. His public image is a disguise, and that disguise is the reason for his isolation. The price of the romance is that Feyre must be the only person who sees past the facade. This creates an “us versus the world” dynamic where their bond is built on shared knowledge that everyone else in their society lacks. However, Rhysand has spent centuries living in a state of psychological dislocation, performing a version of himself that is contrary to who he truly is. His grief, his gentleness, his true values are all concealed beneath the persona. Feyre’s role is not simply to love him; it is to see him, which is its own act of redemption.

The Threat vs. The Reality

The threat of exile is often more useful to your story than exile itself. When your characters can see what happens to people who crossed the same line they’re considering (a disowned sibling, a shunned former courtier, someone whose name is no longer spoken) the cost becomes concrete and personal. You don’t need to exile your protagonist to make exile matter. You just need to show them what exile looks like.

What Exile Strips Away

When building exile customs for your world, think about what the banished person loses beyond location. Do they lose their name? Their family connections? Access to magic? Their place in the afterlife? The more the exile strips away, the higher the cost of the transgression that caused it, and the more your character risks by pursuing a forbidden relationship.

The other key aspect of exile in romantasy is how it ends for the characters. Does exile result in a permanent loss of home and identity? Or can the individual escape their exile and start anew? Can an exiled character create a life outside of their homeland, and will they ever be able to overcome the shame associated with their separation from society? In some fantasy worlds exile results in a form of death sentence for the character. In other worlds exile is considered a social death, where the exiled individual lives on as a physical being but is socially invisible and unable to connect with anyone.

One of the most frequently occurring, and ultimately the most emotionally gratifying, forms of resolution for exile in romantasy is the found family. If a character has been exiled from their natural or culturally defined family, the romance provides more than a partner; it provides a new family for the exiled character. The loved ones' people become the exiled individual's people. Together they construct a home, a court, a rebellion, or a secret city which serves as a replacement for what has been taken from the individual.

The narrative resolution of found family is effective because it recognises that humans need more than romantic love to survive. A person requires community, a sense of belonging, and a sense of purpose to truly thrive. What makes the found family so emotionally powerful is that the exile established what was lost. Therefore, when readers have witnessed you remove the character from every aspect of society, witnessing that same character establish a new existence, one that is developed based upon choice rather than inheritance, carries significant emotional weight.

What does banishment or exile look like in your world?

Physical exile from the territory? Social death while remaining present? Being cut off from family, magic, or community? Loss of name, title, or identity? Inherited stigma that marks the next generation?

YOUR ANSWER

What triggers banishment?

What transgression crosses the line from punishable to unforgivable? Is there a formal process, or can it happen at one person's command?

YOUR ANSWER

Has your character seen someone else face this consequence?

Showing the cost through a secondary character makes the threat real before your protagonists face it. Who in your world has already been cast out, and what happened to them?

YOUR ANSWER

Is exile reversible in your world?

Can the banished return? What would it cost? Is there a path to redemption, or are some falls permanent?

YOUR ANSWER

What replaces the lost community?

If your character is exiled, where do they go? Who takes them in? Does the romance provide not just a partner but a new world to belong to?

YOUR ANSWER

Map your character's exile (actual or threatened):

WHAT THEY LOSE	SPECIFIC DETAILS
Home/territory	
Name/title/identity	
Family connections	
Access to magic or power	

WHAT THEY LOSE	SPECIFIC DETAILS
Community/social belonging	
Sense of self	
What replaces it	

Social Hierarchy in Practice

Even if there were no laws governing how people act in society, people would still find a way to create rules of conduct based on social hierarchy. We all learn the “rules” about how to act toward those higher up in the social order and those lower down. Who enters the room first? Who speaks, and when does the listener get to speak? Who may put a hand on whom? None of this is written into a law book, yet most people understand these unspoken codes and follow them.

In cases where members of different social classes fall in love, all of these unwritten rules become critical. Will the noble acknowledge the servant’s existence? Is it acceptable for the commoner to meet the noble’s eye? All of the tension in such a relationship stems from the disconnect between the roles each partner feels obligated to follow and what they actually feel about one another.

There’s nothing quite like showing that a character has been completely invisible to the upper classes their entire life and now finds themselves truly seen by someone in a position of authority over them. That is electrifying.

You can illustrate social hierarchy through automatic behaviours: who enters the room first, who remains seated while others stand, who speaks and who waits to be spoken to. Each time your characters break one of these automatic behaviours, it indicates a shift in the balance of power. It is at the moment a noble addresses a servant with equality, or a commoner responds to their lord in kind, that the reader feels the change.

The separation of public and private behaviour can be very effective in showing hierarchy. When characters display perfect hierarchy in front of others but fall out of line once they are alone, they are essentially creating their own secret intimacy within that private space.

Look for the “slip”: when a character accidentally reaches for the other person’s hand, uses their first name, or speaks before receiving permission, and then realises what they have done. That instant of “I forgot myself” reveals the true nature of the character beneath the social mask they wear.

Additionally, allow secondary characters to reinforce the consequences of breaking those rules. A servant who observes too much, a rival who keeps track of every detail, a parent who cautions “people are starting to talk.” The hierarchy feels authentic when someone else is paying attention.

What are the unwritten rules of cross-class interaction?

ASPECT	RULE
Eye contact (allowed, forbidden, lowered)	
Forms of address	
Physical proximity	

ASPECT	RULE
Who speaks first	
What topics are appropriate	

What happens when someone violates these unwritten rules?

Social consequences — awkwardness, offense, whispers, retaliation:

YOUR ANSWER

If your characters are from different classes, how do they navigate interaction?

Do they follow the rules? Chafe against them? Have a private space where class doesn't apply?

YOUR ANSWER

What social space allows them to interact more freely than usual?

Markets? Festivals? Neutral territory? Magical spaces? Private chambers?

YOUR ANSWER

What does the “slip” look like between your characters?

The most revealing moments in cross-class romance are the accidental ones — a first name used without thinking, a hand reached for instinctively, eye contact held a beat too long. What moment of “I forgot myself” reveals the truth beneath the social performance?

ASPECT	DETAILS
<i>What the slip is</i>	<i>She calls him by his first name in front of the court — then freezes when she realises what she’s done</i>

ASPECT	DETAILS
What the slip is	
Who slips	
Who notices	
What it reveals	

How do your characters behave differently in public versus private?

When characters maintain perfect hierarchy in front of others but drop it behind closed doors, they create a secret world. What does the shift look like between your characters — and what would happen if someone saw the private version?

CONTEXT	HOW THEY INTERACT
In public (with others watching)	

CONTEXT	HOW THEY INTERACT
In private (alone together)	
What would happen if someone saw the private version	

Language, Names & Forms of Address

The way people interact with each other is how they reveal and create intimacy. The transition from formal to informal communication can be as profound as a first kiss. In many fantasy worlds, names hold a lot of power.

To build anticipation for the name shift, establish the formality at the beginning and let it create tension. Show the characters noticing each other's names, wanting to use them differently, catching themselves. The moment of shift should have some context: who initiated it? Was it asked for, or just assumed? Did the other character reciprocate? Write the physical sensation of the name shift as well. What does a name feel like when you say it out loud for the first time? Hearing your first name said by someone who has never called you anything but your title is vulnerable. Once the shift happens, show the newness of it all: the slight stutter when speaking, the awkwardness, the feeling of being addressed in a manner different than the world addresses you. If one character begins to use the new name before the other is comfortable with it, that disparity in usage is its own form of tension.

What different forms of address exist?

TYPE	EXAMPLES IN YOUR WORLD
Formal (titles, honorifics, surnames)	
Informal (first names, nicknames)	
Intimate (pet names, private names, terms of endearment)	

When is it appropriate to use informal or intimate forms?

Between family? Close friends? Lovers? Only after marriage?

YOUR ANSWER

What shift in address marks a change in relationship?

From title to first name? From formal to informal? A new nickname?

YOUR ANSWER

When do your characters shift how they address each other?

This is often a pivotal intimacy moment:

ASPECT	DETAILS
From	
To	
When and why	

Is there significance to names in your world?

True names with power? Secret names? Multiple names for different contexts?

YOUR ANSWER

What does it mean when one character learns the other's private or true name?

WHAT DOES IT MEAN WHEN ONE CHARACTER LEARNS THE OTHER'S PRIVATE OR TRUE NAME?

Cultural Differences Between Characters

Do your characters come from different cultural backgrounds?

If no, skip to Integration Check.

If yes:

CHARACTER	CULTURE
Protagonist	
Love Interest	

What are the key differences between their cultures?

ASPECT	CULTURE 1	CULTURE 2
Values		
Customs		
Taboos		

What does one culture do that the other finds shocking, rude, or confusing?

MISUNDERSTANDING	DESCRIPTION
1	
2	
3	

What romantic gesture from one culture means something different in the other?

This is prime territory for miscommunication and eventual understanding:

YOUR ANSWER

When do they realize they've been misunderstanding each other?

The revelation scene:

YOUR ANSWER

What cultural tradition does one character teach the other?

The intimacy of sharing worlds:

YOUR ANSWER

Integration Check

QUESTION	YOUR ANSWER
How does government enforce cultural norms? Which taboos are laws vs. “just” social rules? (Ref: Section 5)	
How does magic interact with cultural customs? Magical courtship rituals? Spells that detect rule-breaking? (Ref: Section 8)	
What cultural norm conflicts with your magic system? (Ref: Section 8)	
How do economic realities constrain your characters’ choices? Can they afford to defy convention? (Ref: Section 4)	
What cultural customs have religious origins? Do characters follow them out of faith or habit? (Ref: Section 6)	

QUESTION	YOUR ANSWER
How does your culture's attitude toward sexuality and desire affect your romance's pacing?	

Quick Reference: Cultural Stakes

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD
Core cultural value that most affects your romance	
Main taboo your characters break	
The reputation risk	
The touch or proximity rule that creates tension	

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD
The courtship custom they follow or violate	
The festival or ceremony that matters	
The form of address shift (from → to → when)	
The oath or promise that conflicts with love	
The cultural attitude toward desire that your protagonist must navigate	

Final Thought

Culture Is Behaviour, Not Exposition

Don't info-dump culture. Show it through action: characters following or breaking rules, social awkwardness when norms are violated. The best cultural worldbuilding is invisible until someone breaks the rules, and then everyone knows exactly what line was crossed.